

External arguments in the short passive? The view from Spanish

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Abstract: In this paper, we examine the status of the syntactic projection of the implicit external argument in short periphrastic passive derivations in Spanish. To do this, we apply tests mainly from Collins (2005, 2024) concerning the licensing of agent-oriented secondary depictive predicates, the argument control of big PRO subjects of embedded clauses, the binding of reflexive pronominals, and the non-anaphoric status of non-reflexive pronominals. The results of these tests, placed in a theoretical context of a Minimalist framework (e.g., Chomsky 2021; Chomsky et al. 2023), strongly endorse a view in which the external argument is syntactically-projected in the Spanish short passive. We additionally present novel evidence from Spanish that the reflexive pronominal elements licensed in Spanish short passives cannot plausibly be exempt logophors. In accordance with these theoretical and empirical considerations, we straightforwardly adopt Collins’ (2005, 2024) smuggling approach to the Spanish passive. We further show that several notable properties of the Spanish passive are naturally explained under this smuggling analysis, such as the preverbal, nominative status of the structural subject, the obligatory agreement in phi-features between the participial verb and the subject, and the impossibility of inalienable-possession readings of the short passive, as noted by MacDonald (2017).

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1 Introduction

Spanish is known to have a passive voice construction that exhibits (a) a thematic internal argument (e.g., THEME) as the nominative structural subject with which subject-verb agreement takes place, (b) an auxiliary form of *ser* ‘be’, (c) a participial form of the lexical verb that also agrees in phi-features with the structural subject, and (d) an optional *by*-phrase that expresses the external argument AGENT. These qualities can be seen in the following example.

- (1) La ciudad fue visitada (por muchos turistas).¹
the city was.3SG visited.SG.F (by many tourists)
‘The city was visited by many tourists.’

Structurally, this periphrastic passive construction (as opposed to a *se* passive construction) bears a striking resemblance to passives in other languages, such as English (Collins 2005; 2024) and Italian (Russo Cardona 2026), among others.

There is an open question in the field—with a rich literature dedicated to it—on whether or not short passives (that is, periphrastic passives without a *by*-phrase) involve a syntactically projected external argument. The existence of this question is in large part due to the fact that, despite being interpreted, no external argument appears overtly in short passives (Bhatt & Pancheva 2017). Proposed solutions to this issue tend to come in one of two forms: either by claiming that there is no external argument projected in the syntax, and that the implicit argument interpretation is derived entirely in the semantics (Williams 1985; Pytkänen 2008; Schäfer 2012; Bruening 2013;

¹ In this paper, we follow standard Leipzig glossing conventions. The examples—unless otherwise indicated—reflect the native speaker intuitions of one of the authors.

Legate 2014, 2021; Wood & Marantz 2017; Sigurðsson & Wood 2021, a.o.), or by arguing that there is a covert external argument that is actively projected in the syntax (Baker et al. 1989; Collins 2005, 2024; Landau 2010; Roberts 2019; Angelopoulos et al. 2020; Gotah 2024; Sulemana 2024; Ndapo 2025; Russo Cardona 2026, a.o.).

While both approaches have a number of theoretical and empirical arguments used to support their respective positions, our goal is to argue that the structural and interpretive properties of the short passive in Spanish support a view of a syntactically-realized external argument. Here, we apply and carefully consider several diagnostics mostly from Collins (2024) to Spanish passives that demonstrate the syntactic presence of the external argument (Sect. 2). We also discuss in detail the possibility that anaphoric pronominal expressions that appear in short passives could actually be exempt logophors (e.g., Alexiadou et al. 2015), ultimately showing that a logophoric analysis of these elements is untenable, bolstering a view of the external argument in Spanish short passives being realized in the narrow syntax (Sect. 3). We connect these findings to discussions of the short passive in related language such as English (Collins 2005; 2024) and Italian (Russo Cardona 2026), and advocate for analysis of Spanish periphrastic passives as smuggling derivations (Belletti & Collins 2021; Storment 2025, a.o.), given the empirical situation regarding the projection of the external argument and the goals of Minimalist syntactic theorizing adopted throughout (Sect. 4). We additionally discuss some empirical advantages of the smuggling analysis. Sect. 5 concludes.

2 The syntactic status of the implicit argument

Despite not appearing overtly in short passives, an external argument theta role (e.g., AGENT) is interpreted.

- (2) La novela fue escrita.
the novel was.3SG written.SG.F
‘The novel was written.’

Thus, the event described in (2) is understood as having a writer; however, this interpretive quality on its own is not sufficient to diagnose the presence of a syntactically-projected external argument, as has been extensively discussed in the literature (see Bhatt & Pancheva 2017 for an overview). Nevertheless, there are numerous diagnostics that can be performed to test for the syntactic presence of the external argument. The tests that we carry out here come from Collins (2024) and mainly concern the licit status of elements that require some relation with a syntactic antecedent.

These tests are, of course, not without contention and oft-cited counterexamples (again, see Bhatt & Pancheva 2017, as well as relevant discussions in Collins 2024). As such, in addition to applying these diagnostics to Spanish short passives, we additionally discuss the status of apparent counterexamples to the implications that we take from these tests. These tests include the licensing of secondary depictive predicates (SDPs) (Sect. 2.1), the control of a big PRO subject of an embedded clause (Sect. 2.2), the possibility of coreference between the understood external argument and a bound anaphor (Sect. 2.3), and the impossibility of coreference between the understood external argument and a non-reflexive pronoun (Sect. 2.4).

2.1 Secondary depictive predicates

The first diagnostic that we use here concerns the acceptability of agent-oriented SDPs in short passives. It has been claimed in the literature that SDPs are impossible with short passives in

English. See the following example from Pylkkänen (2008), whose negative judgment (*) is taken to be evidence of the lack of a projected external argument in English short passives.

- (3) *The letter was written drunk. (Pylkkänen’s judgment)

Despite judgments such as this, it has been systematically shown that agent-oriented SDPs are acceptable in English short passives (Roeper 1987; Baker 1988; Stroik 1992; Collins 2005, 2024; Melzer-Asscher 2012, a.o.). In line with these sources, the judgment of the native-speaker author is that the English example in (3) is completely acceptable. There is a similar discussion in the literature for Italian: while SDPs in Italian short passives have been reported as ungrammatical in some sources (e.g., Friengi 2004), it is shown with experimental evidence that many SDPs are quite acceptable in Italian passives (Russo Cardona & Villalba 2025; Russo Cardona 2026).

- (4) Il caldo estivo viene sopportato meglio mezz nudi. (Russo Cardona 2026:63)
the heat summery come.3SG tolerated.SG.M better half.PL.M naked.PL.M
‘Summer heat is better tolerated half naked.’

Similarly, despite prior reports that SDPs are ungrammatical in Spanish short passives (e.g., MacDonald 2017), we find the following utterances to be completely acceptable.

- (5) a. La batalla fue peleada completamente desnudo.
the battle was.3SG fought.SG.F completely naked.SG.M
‘The battle was fought completely naked.’
b. Esta canción debe haber sido escrita borracho.
this song must.3SG have.INF been.SG.M written.SG.F drunk.SG.M
‘This song must have been written drunk.’

In fact, it is also possible to have an agent-oriented SDP with non-default phi-features, which complicates the claim presented by Pitteroff & Schäfer (2019) that the features of SDPs in passives must always be default (i.e., masculine singular in Spanish).²

- (6) La batalla fue peleada completamente desnudos.
the battle was.3SG fought.SG.F completely naked.PL.M
‘The battle was fought completely naked.’

We take this fact as evidence that, not only can agent-oriented SDPs modify the understood external argument interpretively (e.g., the fighter(s) of the battle are nude in (5a) and (6)), but they can clearly also agree for phi-features with an element other than the structural subject.

² The same observation holds for a certain class of null objects in Spanish as well.

(i) Esa música pone triste (-s).
that music puts.3SG sad (-PL)
‘That music makes (one) sad.’

As such, this data point can be connected to other facts about secondary predication of null arguments in Spanish. See Jaeggli (1986) and Suñer (1990, 2002) for discussion.

Williams (1985:308) raises the possibility that the SDP in these kinds of examples is actually modifying the structural subject, rather than any understood external argument. On this, he gives the following English example.

- (7) The game was played nude.

According to Williams, the SDP *nude* in (7) may actually be modifying the subject *the game*, since it is not unreasonable to refer to a game played nude as *a nude game*. See related discussions of this fact in Collins (2024:41) and Bhatt & Pancheva (2006:585).

We find that the Spanish examples given here—as well as the Italian examples cited above—show direct evidence against this kind of assumption. Unlike English, Romance languages like Spanish and Italian show inflection on adjectival elements for gender and number features. Typically, agreement between an adjective and the nominal that it modifies is understood to be obligatory, and adjectival SDPs are no exception to this generalization (Mallén 1991). Thus, the fact that agreement on these SDPs in Spanish has no connection to the features of the structural subject suggests that an analysis in which SDPs modify the structural subject is not tenable.

Furthermore, we can easily observe that SDPs which do modify the structural subject of a passive must obligatorily agree in features with it.

- (8) a. La cerveza debe ser tomada fría.
 the beer must.3SG be.INF taken.SG.F cold.SG.F
 ‘Beer should be drunk cold.’
 b. *La cerveza debe ser tomada frío/ fríos.
 the beer must.3SG be.INF taken.SG.F cold.SG.F/cold.PL.M
 int: ‘Beer should be drunk cold.’

As we see in (5) and (6), there is no such obligatory agreement relation for agent-oriented SDPs in short passives, so the idea that these SDPs are actually modifying the structural subject does not hold up. Additionally, we take the fact that these agent-oriented SDPs can appear with non-default phi-features that do not appear elsewhere in the clause—e.g., the plural feature in (6)—to be evidence that these SDPs are undergoing agreement with something that is present in the syntax of the derivation, but is not overtly realized. The features of adjectival elements are, after all, generally understood to be parasitic on the elements that they modify: i.e., the plural features in (6) should have a source, and, given that there is no overt plural nominal in the clause, we should take the plural features to come from an element that is not seen.

This reasoning, coupled with the fact that the relevant SDPs are straightforwardly interpreted as modifying the understood agent of the main clause (such that (5b) carries the clear interpretation that it is the writer of the song who was drunk), suggests that there is a covert external argument AGENT in these examples by which the SDPs are controlled, both in terms of their morphosyntactic featural makeup and their semantic interpretation.

Here, we acknowledge the fact that there are semantic theories of control (Jackendoff 1972; Williams 1985), argument structure (e.g., Williams 2015), and agreement (Smith 2017; Corbett 2023), which do not necessarily assume that an element must be present in the syntax in order to be interpreted, to control other elements, and even to be agreed with. We explicitly do not adopt these notions, though, for the issues of restrictiveness (see Collins 2024, chapter 10) that they raise and the costs that we perceive them to incur of significant complications to our model of the human language faculty. If it is truly the case that any argument can be interpreted in any position without

actually having to be present in the syntax and can have direct effects in the syntax such as control and even agreement, then there arises a concern about vast overgeneration, and much additional work will have to be done in the model to ensure that superfluous arguments cannot appear freely in utterances where their interpretation is not licensed.

Take, for example, the fact that agent-oriented SDPs plainly cannot appear with verbs that are accepted to not project an external argument, such as unaccusative verbs or verbs marked with inchoative *se*.

- (9) a. *La batalla empezó completamente desnudo.
 the battle began.3SG completely naked.SG.M
 int: ‘The battle began completely naked.’
 b. *La batalla se acabó completamente desnudo.
 the battle SE ended.3SG completely naked.SG.M
 int: ‘The battle ended completely naked.’

The reason why the SDP is not available in (9), even though a plausible interpretation is available (which is that the battle began/ended with all the participants naked), is not obvious under a theory in which arguments need not actually be present in the syntax in order to be interpreted, bind, and control agreement. In fact, the contrast between (9) and (5a) is especially puzzling under this view.

These data are more simply explained by assuming that there is a covert external argument projected in the narrow syntax of short passives in Spanish, an assumption that itself is already motivated: unpronounced, syntactically-active external arguments are already attested in Spanish (see the null-subject parameter) In the following sub-sections, we present further empirical support and discussions of the claim that the external argument is syntactically-projected in Spanish short passives. For more work using the agreement features of SDPs to diagnose the presence of covert arguments, see Storment (2026b). We return in more detail to the advantages of a theory in which the external argument is projected in the syntax of short passives in Sect. 3.3.

2.2 Control of PRO

The next test to diagnose the presence of the external argument comes from the licit control of a big PRO subject of an embedded non-finite clause, a test that is also not without contention (again, see Bhatt & Pancheva 2017 for an overview).

In Spanish, short passives can appear with an embedded non-finite purpose clause. See the following.

- (10) a. La leche fue hervida para preparar el pastel.
 the milk was.3SG boiled.SG.F for prepare.INF the cake
 ‘The milk was boiled (in order) to make the cake.’
 b. La guerra fue empezada para tomar el control del territorio.
 the war was.3SG begun.SG.F for take.INF the control of.the territory
 ‘The war was started (in order) to take control of the territory.’

Notably, such embedded clauses are not licensed with unaccusative/inchoative verbs that do not project an external argument, just as was the case with SDPs.

- (11) a. *La leche hirvió para preparar el pastel.
 the milk boiled.3SGfor prepare.INF el cake
int: ‘The milk boiled (in order) to prepare the cake.’
 b. *La guerra empezó para tomar el control del territorio.
 the war began.3SGfor take.INF the control of.the territory
int: ‘The war started (in order) to take control of the territory.’

The contrast between (10) and (11) shows plainly that passive contexts allow control of an embedded PRO, while unaccusative contexts do not. In the passive contexts in (10), the interpretation of the subject of the embedded clause clearly and unambiguously is associated with the understood external argument of the matrix clause: in (a), the boiler of the milk is clearly understood to be the person who intends to prepare the cake; in (b), the party responsible for starting the war is clearly understood to be the party that intends to take control of the territory.

While the same interpretations are perhaps conceptually plausible for the respective examples in (11), they are not able to be grammatically realized in this way. Again, the simplest explanation for this contrast—as well as for the interpretive facts described—is that there is a syntactically-projected external argument that is able to control the PRO subject of the embedded clause in short passive contexts, but not in unaccusative contexts.

It should not be taken for granted, though, that the ability of a purpose adjunct clause with a PRO subject to appear embedded in a grammatical utterance necessarily indicates that there is a control relation between that embedded PRO subject and a matrix external argument. On this, much ink has been spilt (Williams 1974, 1985; Bruening 2013; Williams 2014; Bhatt & Pancheva 2017; Russo Cardona 2026, a.o.). For instance, cases of arbitrary control or so-called S-control have been claimed as a counterexample to the idea that the control of an embedded PRO subject in the short passive is evidence of a syntactically-active external argument. See here the well-known example from Williams (1974, 1985).

- (12) Grass is green to promote photosynthesis. (Williams 1985:310)

Indeed, the same utterance is possible in Spanish.

- (13) El pasto es verde para promover la fotosíntesis.
 the grass is green for promote.INF the photosynthesis
 ‘Grass is green to promote photosynthesis.’

Such examples are often used as a counterexample to the claim that sentences such as those in (10) involve a syntactically-projected external argument (Williams 1985; Bhatt & Pancheva 2017:9). Whether the example in (12) does indeed complicate our understanding of the examples in (10)—or whether it is relevant at all to our understanding of (10)—is something that should be carefully considered before being brought up as a definitive claim (a point which has again been brought up by others: e.g., Bhatt & Pancheva 2017; Russo Cardona 2026).

It is certainly true that there is no interpretive connection between the embedded subject and some understood agent of the matrix clause in (12), nor would it be reasonable to claim that the grammaticality of (12) is somehow indicative of the presence of an external argument agent in the matrix clause. Both interpretively and formally, there is no reason to believe that there is an external argument agent controlling the PRO subject of the embedded clause.

As Williams (1985) notes, the controller of the PRO subject in (12) seems to be the entire matrix clause (hence “S-control”). This observation indeed corresponds to the interpretation of the embedded agent: in (12), the promoter of photosynthesis is more or less understood to be the greenness of the grass, or the grass’s quality of being green. The same interpretation holds of the Spanish example in (13).

Returning to the passive examples in (10), there is no such relation of S-control: in (11a), the event of the milk being boiled is not understood to be coreferent with the intended baker of the cake, and, in (11b), the event of the war’s beginning is not understood to be the entity that intends to take control of the territory. In fact, such interpretations are quite nonsensical. It should also be noted that the interpretive properties of the embedded subjects in (10) are not at all characteristic of arbitrary control, either.

This is all to say that the interpretive qualities of the control of the embedded subjects in (10) and (12) are completely different from one another. While it is true that the examples in (12) and (13) show that control of a PRO subject of an embedded, non-finite purpose clause do not need to involve an external argument agent in the matrix clause in every instance, these examples bear no relevance on the fact that there is a straightforward interpretive link between the understood external argument agent of the matrix short passive clause and the PRO subject of the embedded purpose clause in (10), a fact that straightforwardly follows from an account of the short passive as involving a syntactically-projected external argument.

As such, a discussion of the status of examples like (12) and (13) is a bit of a red herring with respect to the question of the status of the external argument in the short passive, since these examples have actually very little relevance to the interpretation of the controlled embedded PRO subjects in short passive contexts such as (10). It is also worth mentioning that such S-control interpretations are not available as a grammatical interpretation in (11), either, further suggesting that the availability of S-control is not relevant to the passive examples discussed here. The same is true of other cases such as so-called “remote control” (e.g., Williams 2014) or arbitrary control that do not involve a clear interpretive link between the external argument of the main clause and the external argument of the embedded clause, as is the case with these short passive examples.

Given these considerations on the interpretation of the relevant control relations, as well as the theoretical considerations outlined in the previous sub-section, the simplest understanding of the contrast between (10) and (11) is that the passive examples in (10) involve a syntactically-projected external argument in the matrix clause that controls the PRO subject of the matrix clause. There is no such possibility for an embedded clause of this kind in the unaccusative contexts in (11) because the matrix clauses do not project an external argument (and S-control is independently unavailable for these unaccusative examples, perhaps due to their episodic nature).

One should take explicit note of the fact that these examples and their implications mirror those concerning SDPs in the previous sub-section. As such, we have now seen two empirical phenomena that straightforwardly suggest that there is a syntactically-projected external argument in Spanish short passives. Once again, see related discussions for Italian in Russo Cardona (2026).

2.3 Bound anaphora (Principle A)

The next diagnostic concerns the licit appearance of reflexive pronouns in short passive clauses and their interpretation as bound anaphors. Here, we look at anaphoric pronominal expressions involving the reflexive element *mismo(s)* (or *misma(s)*, depending on the inflection). Again, see similar tests involving English reflexive pronouns with *self* from Collins (2005, 2024) and Italian reflexive pronouns with *stesso* from Russo Cardona (2026).

We see that Principle A of the Binding Theory (14) typically applies to pronominal expressions involving *mismo* (15)-(16), though this is crucially not without exception (see Sect. 3).

(14) *Principle A of the Binding Theory* (from Sportiche, Koopman & Stabler 2014:168)
An anaphor must be bound in its domain.

(15) a. *Juan hizo la tarea por mí mismo.
Juan did.3SG the task for me same.M
int: ‘Juan did the homework by myself.’
b. Yo hice la tarea por mí mismo.
I did.1SG the task for me same.M
‘I did the homework by myself.’

(16) a. *Yo escribí la carta a ti misma.
I wrote.1SG the letter to you same.F
int: ‘I wrote the letter to yourself.’
b. Tú escribiste la carta a ti misma.
you wrote.2SG the letter to you same.F
‘You wrote the letter to yourself.’

It is typically the case, then, that reflexive pronominal expressions with *mismo* are subject to Principle A and must be locally bound by a syntactically-projected antecedent.

(17) *Se derretió el hielo por mí mismo.
SE melted.3SG the ice for me same
int: ‘The ice melted by myself.’ (i.e., ‘The ice melted of my own accord.’)

(18) *Una carta llegó para mí mismo.
a letter arrived.3SG for me same
int: ‘The letter arrived for myself.’

As such, we see that utterances which lack a syntactically-projected external argument, such as unaccusatives/inchoatives, are not able to license an anaphoric expression involving *mismo* that is coreferent with an intended external argument interpretation. In other words, we find (17) and (18) to be ungrammatical, and it is certainly not the case that there is a salient intended interpretation in which the reflexive expressions are coreferent with some understood agent: e.g., the reflexive in (17) could not be understood as the melter of the ice, nor could the reflexive in (18) be understood as somehow referring to the sender of the letter.

Returning to the short passive, we see that reflexive pronominals with *mismo* are acceptable.³

(19) a. Este cambio fue hecho por mí mismo.
this change was.3SG done.SG.M for me same
‘This change was made by myself.’

³ Collins (2024) and Russo Cardona (2026) reproduce examples from this kind systematically collected from Internet searches for English and Italian, respectively. We choose not to do this, as the grammaticality judgments are clear, though we make a point of noting that it is also the case for Spanish that one can easily find such examples online.

- b. Nada de este trabajo puede ser hecho por ti mismo.
 nothing of this work can.3SG be.INF done.SG.M by you same
 ‘None of this work can be done by yourself.’
- (20) a. Ese libro fue escrito para mí mismo.
 that book was.3SG written.SG.M for me same
 ‘That book was written for myself.’
- b. Es una película que fue hecha para sí mismo, y para los demás.
 is.3SG a film that was.3SG made.SG.F for self same, and for the others
 ‘It’s a film that was made for himself, and also for other people.’
- (21) a. Es una carta que te fue enviada a ti mismo.
 is a letter that you.CL was.3SG sent.SG.F to you same
 ‘It’s a letter that was sent to yourself.’
- b. Este fue un regalo dado a mí mismo.
 this was.3SG a gift given.SG.M to me same
 ‘This was a gift given to myself.’
- c. Estas son palabras que nunca deben ser dichas a uno mismo.
 these are.3PL words that never should.3PL be.INF said.SG.F to one same
 ‘These are words that should never be said to oneself.’

Not only are these examples grammatical, but, crucially, the reflexive pronominal expressions exclusively carry bound anaphoric readings. Taking (21c), for instance, it is only the case that the reflexive recipient *a uno mismo* ‘to oneself’ is coreferent with the understood agent of the lexical verb *dichas* ‘said’: the recipient is unambiguously coreferent with the sayer of the words, and no other interpretation is available (i.e., it is not possible that AGENT $\neq$ RECIPIENT). This interpretive restriction holds for all of the other examples given in (19) through (21). Therefore, these reflexive pronominal expressions are interpreted as bound anaphors just as they are in the grammatical examples from (15) and (16), an interpretation which is not possible in (17) and (18).

Once again, these facts straightforwardly suggest that there is an argument present in the syntax that binds the anaphoric expressions in the short passive examples in (19)-(21). It has been suggested in the literature that such reflexive elements in passives could conceivably be analyzed as non-anaphoric logophors (a.k.a. exempt anaphors, since they are allegedly exempt from Principle A) (Reed 2011; Schäfer 2012; Alexiadou et al. 2015, a.o.). While we return to a much more detailed discussion of this point in Sect. 3, it is sufficient here to note that the interpretive fact that the reflexives (19)-(21) can only be interpreted as bound anaphors poses a major complication for the idea that these elements could be exempt logophors.

2.4 Non-bound pronouns (Principle B)

In addition to the fact that reflexive pronominal expressions must be interpreted as bound anaphors in short passive environments such as (19)-(21), it is also the case that non-reflexive pronominals cannot have a bound reading in the same contexts. Again, Collins (2024) applies the same tests to English passives.

In the environments where reflexive pronominals appear in the previous sub-section, it is also possible to realize non-reflexive pronominals without *mismo*. We show this here, skipping the sentences in (19) since expressions such as ‘by X’s self’ are typically understood to be inherently

reflexive and thus removing the reflexive changes the interpretation in such a way that detracts from the focus of the argumentation here.

- (22) a. Ese libro fue escrito para mí.
that book was.3SG written.SG.M for me
'That book was written for me.'
- b. Es una película que fue hecha para él.
is.3SG a film that was.3SG made.SG.F for him
'It's a film that was made for him.'
- (23) a. Es una carta que te fue enviada a ti.
is a letter that you.CL was.3SG sent.SG.F to you
'It's a letter that was sent to you.'
- b. Este fue un regalo dado a mí.
this was.3SG a gift given.SG.M to me
'This was a gift given to me.'
- c. Estas son palabras que nunca nos deben ser dichas a nosotros.
these are.3PL words that never us.CL should.3PL be.INF said.SG.F to us
'These are words that should never be said to us.'

Here, we find that, in a sense, the inverse of the generalization of the previous sub-section is true. In these examples in (22) and (23), a bound interpretation of the pronominal non-reflexive recipient phrases is not possible at all.

In (22b), it is not possible that the recipient is coreferent with the understood agent: the maker of the film cannot be who the film was made for. This judgment is clear. Similarly, in (23b), it is impossible that the giver of the gift is also the recipient of the gift (AGENT $\neq$ RECIPIENT). These facts are consistent with the behavior of these pronominal expressions in clauses with an overt external argument.

- (24) a. *Yo me di el regalo a mí.⁴
I me.CL gave.1SG the gift to me
int: 'I gave the gift to me.'
- b. Tú me diste el regalo a mí.
you me.CL gave.2SG the gift to me
'You gave the gift to me.'

⁴ While we do find that an acceptable reading of examples such as (24a) involving a bound anaphoric first person object lacking reflexive morphology can be coerced in the right pragmatic situation (e.g., with heavy contrastive focus on *a mí* 'to me'), what is crucial here is that it is far more natural and unmarked to have reflexive morphology with *mismo* on the strong object pronoun. Further, a bound anaphoric reading of a third person object without reflexive morphology is absolutely not possible in this same context.

- (ii) Juan_i se dio el regalo a él_i *(mismo).
Juan_i SE gave.3SG the gift to him_i *(same)
Juan gave the gift to himself.

Thus, we find that these generalizations about Principle B effects are still tenable, despite the fact that there is a coercible bound reading conditionally available in examples such as (24a).

Furthermore, these non-reflexive pronominals are licensed in unaccusative/inchoative contexts, since they are not bound by an external argument (since there is no external argument).

- (25) Una carta llegó para mí.
 a letter arrived.3SG para me
 ‘The letter arrived to me.’

To the degree that we can understand there to be an understood sender in this example, there is no obvious coreference relationship between it and the recipient. But, there is no external argument in these unaccusative contexts that would even be a plausible candidate for binding the recipient.

These facts show that Principle B holds of these non-reflexive pronominal expressions.

- (26) *Principle B of the Binding Theory* (from Sportiche, Koopman & Stabler 2014:170)
 An pronoun cannot be bound in its domain.

If we are to take the examples in (22) and (23) at face value, along with their interpretive properties, in corroboration with the implications of the Principle A examples and their interpretations from the previous sub-section, we see further direct evidence for the existence of a syntactically-projected external argument in the Spanish short passive.

We do not doubt the possibility of giving the set of facts from this sub-section and the previous one a treatment in which the interpretive properties of these sentences are derived entirely in the semantics (e.g., from the formal semantic properties of abstract functional heads). Such an analysis is certainly conceivable; however, all of the facts presented thus far are easily accounted for under an analysis of an external argument being syntactically projected in the Spanish short passive. Once again, we assume that these data points indicate the behavior of an external argument being present. In the following section, we discuss advantages that this analysis bears over alternative explanations.

3 On logophoricity

In Sects. 2.3 and 2.4, we have shown that pronominal expressions such as recipient phrases in Spanish short passives are subject to Principles A and B of the Binding Theory. These data and their interpretations support a view in which an external argument is syntactically projected in these contexts. The possibility that the reflexive pronominals from Sect. 2.3 could actually be logophoric expressions that are exempt from Principle A (e.g., Reed 2011; Schäfer 2012; Alexiadou et al. 2015, a.o.) should still be explicitly ruled out, though. Here, we follow Collins’ (2024:32) discussion on logophoricity, applying the discussion to Spanish, which allows for some novel empirical insights due to morphological distinctions not made in English (Sect. 3.2).

3.1 Alternation with non-reflexive pronouns

As Sect. 2.3 shows, the reflexive pronominals in the short passive examples in (19)-(21) obligatorily have a bound interpretation. Conversely, a bound reading for the non-reflexive pronominals is impossible in the same contexts. These facts on their own suggest that the reflexive pronominals are not logophoric, but we can go a bit further with the argumentation here.

Pronominal expressions with reflexive morphology *mismo* can also function as logophoric pronouns that do not have a bound anaphor interpretation. See the following.

- (27) a. En cuanto a mí mismo, el problema persiste.
 in how.much to me same, the problem persist.3SG
 ‘As for myself, the problem persists.’
 b. Según nosotros mismos, la tierra es plana.
 following we same, the earth is flat
 ‘According to ourselves, the earth is flat.’
 c. Ella nos vio a Juan y a mí mismo.
 she us.CL saw.3SG to Juan and to me same
 ‘She saw Juan and myself.’

These kinds of exempt logophors in (27) can appear in contexts such as certain topic phrases (a, b) and inside of coordinate structures (c) (Charnavel 2019). Notably, these logophoric pronominal expressions do not have a bound anaphor interpretation: that is, they are not necessarily coreferent with some antecedent. This fact already sets them apart from the short passive examples in (19)-(21). Additionally, non-reflexive pronominal expressions can appear in the same environments. See the following minimal pairs for the examples in (27).

- (28) a. En cuanto a mí, el problema persiste.
 in how.much to me, the problem persist.3SG
 ‘As for myself, the problem persists.’
 b. Según nosotros, la tierra es plana.
 following we, the earth is flat
 ‘According to ourselves, the earth is flat.’
 c. Ella nos vio a Juan y a mí.
 she us.CL saw.3SG to Juan and to me
 ‘She saw Juan and myself.’

Crucially, there is no clear semantic difference between the examples in (27) and those in (28). There is arguably a pragmatic difference in which the reflexive pronominals bear more emphasis in (27) than the non-reflexive pronominals in (28), but, in terms of the binding facts and how the pronominals are interpreted with respect to the other arguments of the clause, there is no difference. This is indeed a property of logophoric pronouns: they can alternate with morphologically non-reflexive pronouns without changing the core semantic meaning of the utterance (Lebeaux 1984; Charnavel & Zlogar 2015; Charnavel & Bryant 2022; Collins 2024).

Once again, this is not the case for the short passive. Take a minimal pair from Sects. 2.3 and 2.4, repeated here.

- (29) a. Este fue un regalo dado a mí mismo.
 this was.3SG a gift given.SG.M a me same
 ‘This was a gift given to myself.’
 b. Este fue un regalo dado a mí.
 this was.3SG a gift given.SG.M a me
 ‘This was a gift given to me.’

Here, we have a clear interpretive difference between (29a) and (29b) beyond emphasis, which is that the agent and recipient are necessarily coreferent in (29a), but cannot be coreferent in (29b).

There is no such contrast between (27) and (28). This should be taken as evidence that the reflexive in (32a) is a true bound anaphor, and not an exempt logophor, since it does not behave like one.

3.2 The reflexive pronoun *sí*

For further evidence that the short passives in Spanish can bind a true reflexive anaphor, let us examine the distribution of the third person strong reflexive pronoun *sí*. In order to do this, we must look at the nature of third person pronominal expressions involving *mismo* as a whole.

Third person reflexive bound anaphors with *mismo* can either involve a canonical third person strong pronoun—e.g., *él*, *ella*, *ell(o/a)s*—or the dedicated reflexive strong pronoun *sí*. See the following examples involving canonically-bound anaphors.

- (30) a. Julio se vio a él mismo en el espejo.
Julio SE saw.3SG to him same in the mirror
'Julio saw himself in the mirror.'
- b. María se envió una carta a ella misma.
María SE sent.3SG a letter to her same
'María sent a letter to herself.'
- c. Los estudiantes dieron una fiesta para ellos mismos.
the students gave.3PL a party for them same
'The students threw a party for themselves.'
- (31) a. Julio se vio a sí mismo en el espejo.
Julio SE saw.3SG to REFL same in the mirror
'Julio saw himself in the mirror.'
- b. María se envió una carta a sí misma.
María SE sent.3SG a letter to REFL same
'María sent a letter to herself.'
- c. Los estudiantes dieron una fiesta para sí mismos.
the students gave.3PL a party for REFL same
'The students threw a party for themselves.'

There is perhaps a pragmatic difference between the examples in (30) and their counterparts in (31) involving emphasis or some degree of perspectival centering, though we consider this point mostly peripheral to the core argumentation here. What matters is that, in the case of true bound reflexive anaphors in the third person, both the standard strong pronoun and the reflexive strong pronoun *sí* are possible.

Looking at cases of exempt logophors, it is quite clear that, while canonical third person strong pronouns are licensed, the reflexive strong pronoun *sí* is not.

- (32) a. En cuanto a él mismo, el problema persiste.
in how.much to him same, the problem persist.3SG
'As for himself, the problem persists.'
- b. Según ella misma, la tierra es plana.
following she same, the earth is flat
'According to herself, the earth is flat.'

- c. Juan y ella misma me vieron.
 Juan and she same me.CL saw.3PL
 ‘Juan and herself saw me.’
- (33) a. *En cuanto a sí mismo, el problema persiste.
 in how.much to REFL same, the problem persist.3SG
int: ‘As for himself, the problem persists.’
 b. *Según sí misma, la tierra es plana.
 following REFL same, the earth is flat
int: ‘According to herself, the earth is flat.’
 c. *Juan y sí misma me vieron.
 Juan and REFL same me.CL saw.3PL
int: ‘Juan and herself saw me.’

This clear contrast indicates that the third person strong reflexive pronoun *sí* is only licensed as a true bound anaphor, and cannot appear as an exempt logophor.

Turning now to short passives, we see that both the canonical *el-* series of third person strong pronouns as well as the reflexive pronoun *sí* are licensed in reflexive pronominal expressions with *mismo*. See the following, in which we present the minimal pairs together.⁵

- (34) a. Es una carta que fue escrita a él mismo.
 is.3SG a letter that was.3SG written.SG.F to him same
 ‘It’s a letter that was written to himself.’
 b. Es una carta que fue escrita a sí mismo.
 is.3SG a letter that was.3SG written.SG.F to REFL same
 ‘It’s a letter that was written to himself.’
- (35) a. Este fue un regalo dado a ella misma.
 this was.3SG a gift given.SG.M to her same
 ‘This was a gift given to herself.’
 b. Este fue un regalo dado a sí misma.
 this was.3SG a gift given.SG.M to REFL same
 ‘This was a gift given to herself.’
- (36) a. La tumba fue preparada para él mismo.
 the tomb was.3SG prepared.SG.F for him same
 ‘The tomb was prepared for himself.’
 b. La tumba fue preparada para sí mismo.
 the tomb was.3SG prepared.SG.F for REFL same
 ‘The tomb was prepared for himself.’

Given that the third person reflexive pronoun *sí* is licensed in these short passive contexts, it is clear that the reflexive pronominals in these examples cannot be exempt logophors, since *sí* is not licensed as an exempt logophor. This finding is consistent with how these elements are interpreted. For instance, in both sentences (36), it is necessarily the case that the recipient is coreferent with

⁵ For some, the (a) examples here in (34)-(36) may be odd without some additional context.

the agent: the preparer of the tomb is who the tomb is intended for (Agent = Recipient). Indeed, this interpretation must hold of the sentences in (34) and (35) as well. So, in addition to the fact that these pronominals with *mismo* morphologically behave like bound anaphors with the licensing of *sí*, they also behave like true bound anaphors in their interpretations.

And, furthermore, we see again that neither *mismo*-expressions with the *el*- series of third person strong pronouns nor those with reflexive *sí* are possible in unaccusative contexts.

- (37) a. *La carta llegó para él mismo.
 the letter arrived.3SG for him same
 b. *La carta llegó para sí mismo.
 the letter arrived.3SG for REFL same
 int: ‘The letter arrived to himself.’

This fact with unaccusatives further corroborates the story that *sí* is only possible as a bound anaphor, and thus is not available when there is no argument to bind it, and that short passives do contain an external argument that is able to bind the true anaphoric pronoun.

The facts concerning the distribution of the reflexive strong pronoun *sí* presents a clear piece of evidence that the reflexive elements that are licit in short passive contexts cannot be exempt logophors. Collins (2024) discusses issues of logophoricity in detail for English short passives, though English lacks any sort of morphological distinction between logophoric pronouns and true anaphors. As such, this point from Spanish is an additional argument in favor of the bound-anaphor approach to these elements, which strengthens the case that a syntactically-projected external argument is part of the derivation of short passives. Thus, English and Spanish short passives can be further unified in this way.

Spanish is, of course, not the only language in which there are morphological differences between exempt logophors and true reflexive anaphors, and this has not gone unnoticed in the literature. Angelopoulos et al. (2020) show that there is also a true anaphoric pronominal in Greek that is not possible as an exempt logophor and can also appear in short passives. Further, Russo Cardona (2026) discusses in detail the licensing of the Italian counterpart of the Spanish reflexive strong pronoun *sí*, showing that it also cannot be a logophor and is licensed in Italian short passives.

3.3 Further considerations

Thus far in this section, we have shown that reflexive pronominals with *mismo* in short passive contexts do not behave like exempt logophors, in terms of their interpretive properties, alternation with non-reflexive pronominals, and whether or not they license the third person reflexive strong pronoun *sí*.

Of course, there is a very rich literature on the intricacies and complexities of the issues that come up around delineating the boundaries between anaphoricity and logophoricity (e.g., Lebeaux 1984; Pollard & Sag 1992; Reinhart & Reuland 1993; Anagnostopoulou & Everaert 1999; Charnavel 2019; Charnavel & Zlogar 2015; Charnavel & Bryant 2022, a.o.). Indeed, there are semantic theories of anaphor binding that do not assume that anaphors need to be “bound” in the traditional sense at all (e.g., Pollard & Sag 1992; Culicover & Jackendoff 1995). Conversely, there are theories that argue that all instances of logophors are actually syntactically bound by covert elements such as operators, such that they are not actually “exempt” from Condition A in the traditional sense (e.g., Charnavel 2019; Charnavel & Zlogar 2015).

To get into the weeds of the details of these theories and the most nuanced-as-possible approach to anaphoricity as possible is well beyond the scope of this paper. What is clear, though, is that there are morphological, interpretive, and combinatoric differences between elements that are traditionally considered bound anaphors and elements that are traditionally considered exempt logophors. These differences bring up two important considerations.

First, it is imperative for a theory to adequately account for these differences. As previously stated, in line with the scientific and Minimalist-theoretic goals of this paper to pursue the simplest explanation that accounts for the data by adopting a straightforward mapping between syntax and semantics as well as a maximally parsimonious theory of argument structure (e.g., Collins 2024), we explain these observations in terms of the need of reflexive anaphors to be bound by a syntactic antecedent, without introducing any other complications. For example, if one assumes that neither logophors nor anaphors need to actually be bound in order to be licensed, then there is still an additional burden to explain the empirical differences between anaphors and logophors.

Second, it is clear that Spanish reflexive pronominal expressions in short passives behave like what are traditionally considered bound anaphors, and not like what are traditionally considered exempt logophors. Thus, our explanation obtains adequate empirical coverage here under an analysis of these anaphoric elements in short passive contexts being bound by a syntactically-projected external argument. Our analysis here is thereby consistent with other analyses of short periphrastic passives in other languages, such as English (Collins 2025; 2024), Italian (Russo Cardona 2026), and Greek (Angelopoulos et al. 2020).

It could conceivably be the case that these anaphors are licensed by the featural composition of an abstract head (i.e., a [D] feature on Voice) instead of an actual argument that is active in the syntax (e.g., Legate 2014, a.o.), though we find that such approaches suppose additional complications to the theory, such as feature bundling and an excessively powerful notion of formal semantics driving syntactic derivations, specifically argument structure. For instance, if there is a bound anaphor interpretation of a reflexive pronominal recipient in a short passive in which it is coreferent with the external argument, but the anaphor is not actually bound by any external argument, then we must assume that there is some additional work taking place at some point in the semantic derivation of the utterance to ensure that (a) the external argument is interpreted at all, and (b) that the recipient is coreferent with the external argument. This is additional labor that does not have to be assumed under a view that the external argument is simply present in the derivation, and interpreted as such (see again Collins 2024).

The aforementioned Voice-head-composition theories (e.g., Pylkkänen 2008; Bruening 2013, a.o.) also assume additional mechanisms such as feature bundling which present further complications to a theory in which syntactic derivations are built exclusively via Merge (Chomsky et al. 2019; Chomsky 2021, 2024; Chomsky et al. 2023; Collins & Kayne 2023). Such a complication is not present under a view in which an external argument is added into a derivation (in the same way that all arguments are) via External Merge. On this, Chomsky et al. (2023:12) state as “a guiding principle” that “Merge must take the simplest possible form, and the number of additional structure-building operations should be minimized (ideally, entirely eliminated)”.

Indeed, this alternative conception is radically simpler: a theory of semantic interpretation in which semantic values are assigned directly to corresponding syntactically-projected structures, and relations such as control and agreement directly follow from relations between elements in the narrow syntax (Chomsky 1981, 2021; Landau 2000; Collins 2024, a.o.). Under this view, the behavior of reflexive pronominals in the short passive sentences is straightforwardly accounted

for, as are the behaviors of SDPs and embedded PRO subjects, as they follow from the syntactic projection of the external argument in the short passive in Spanish.

Given that the syntactic account offers a natural, straightforward explanation of several facts outlined here while the semantic account does not, as well as the fact that the latter account does not assume a powerful notion of formal semantics that is capable of assigning any interpretive relation to elements that may or may not be present in the structure, which would significantly complicate the mechanisms needed to derive natural language utterances, we assume that the latter account is preferable for reasons of maximal simplicity that are ideally assumed within a Minimalist syntactic framework. On this, see the following:

- (38) ‘Naturally, one seeks the simplest account of UG. One reason is just normal science: it has long been understood that simplicity of theory is essentially the same as depth of explanation. But for language there is an extra reason: UG is the theory of the biological endowment of the language faculty, and each complication of UG therefore poses a barrier to some eventual account of the origin of language, to the extent that this can be attained.’ (Chomsky 2015:3-4)
- (39) ‘One third-factor principle associated with computation involves a form of simplicity: less computation is simpler than more. Of course this is not unique to linguistics; it’s a scientific truism representing the basic methodology of science.’ (Chomsky et al. 2023:17)
- (40) ‘There is an independent reason to seek maximal simplicity. The goal of serious inquiry is explanation, which deepens as greater simplicity of theory is achieved. That maxim has been the guiding motive for the “generative enterprise” since its inception. The search is reflected in successive versions of UG over the years. Each step sought a simpler formulation of UG with fewer language-specific conditions (LSCs), hence deeper explanation...’ (Chomsky 2023, 25:18)

In accordance with these considerations, we pursue the simplest explanation of the data examined here, both in terms of empirical coverage and theoretical stipulations that must be assumed, given that parsimony of the architecture of the grammar is a desirable goal in Minimalist theorizing. If an implicit argument is clearly interpreted and has demonstrable effects in the syntax (e.g., agreement, binding), then we consider the far simpler explanation to be that the argument is present in the syntax even though it does not appear overtly, as opposed to introducing a complicated notion of formal semantics into the theory of argument structure to account for these effects. In line with the scientific goals stated in (38)-(40), which are central to the Minimalist program, we should adopt simplest explanation until such a point that it is no longer proven to be tenable, and we have yet to see any evidence that argues directly against the presence of an external argument in Spanish short passives

4 Smuggling derivation of the passive

Thus far, we have gone through several tests to show that there is a syntactically-projected external argument in Spanish periphrastic passive clauses, including the licensing of agent-oriented SDPs, the control of embedded PRO non-finite subjects, and the adherence to Conditions A and B of the Binding Theory. We have additionally discussed in detail how it is theoretically advantageous to

assume a syntactically-realized external argument in these contexts within a Minimalist framework. In this section, we demonstrate that, given the presence of the implicit external argument in the narrow syntax, the Spanish short passive is best conceived of as a smuggling derivation (Collins 2005, 2024; Belletti & Collins 2021; Storment 2025, 2026a; Russo Cardona 2026, a.o.), which is further in accordance with the Minimalist principles adopted in this paper.

4.1 The position of arguments

If we are indeed on the right track in assuming that there is a syntactically-projected external argument in the short passive, there is an obvious question to answer of where that argument is located in the syntactic structure, especially in relation to the thematic internal argument that is promoted to the position of structural subject in passive contexts.

In normal transitive clauses (i.e., in non-passive contexts), the external argument is promoted to the position of structural subject, and not the internal argument. This is especially true of an SVO language like Spanish or English. So, there are actually two questions to ponder: where the arguments of a short passive start out (i.e., where they are externally Merged), and where the arguments end up (i.e., where they move to).

Here, in accordance with the theoretical principles assumed throughout the paper, we maintain a strong notion of uniformity and consistency in argument structure, or in the projection of the thematic arguments within a clause. We adopt notions that are compatible with Configurational Theta-Theory (Gruber 1997; Gruber & Collins 1997), the Theta-Criterion (Chomsky 1986), and the Argument Criterion (Collins 2024): the idea thematic arguments are uniformly projected across utterances, and that specific positions correspond transparently to specific thematic interpretations. These are notions that underly a descriptive generalization such as UTAH (Baker 1988), and are central to a theory that assumes a transparent and straightforward mapping between syntactic structure and semantic interpretation. On this, see Chomsky’s (2021) *Duality of Semantics*, in which the position in which an argument is externally Merged directly corresponds to its thematic interpretation, which is framed as a central consequence of the Strong Minimalist Thesis (SMT), or the conjecture that “UG reduces to the simplest computational principles” (Chomsky & Berwick 2016:94).

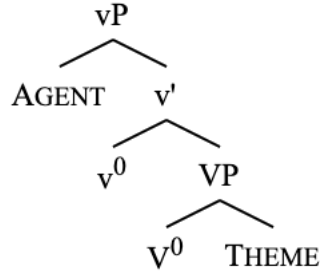
- (41) *Duality of Semantics* (Chomsky 2021:18)
EM [External Merge] is associated with θ -roles and IM [Internal Merge] with discourse/information-related functions.

In adopting this notion of a clear association between thematic interpretation and the position into which an argument is merged (i.e., a straightforward mapping between semantic meaning and argument structure), we do not assume an alternative conceptualization in which a powerful notion of formal semantics is capable of connecting arguments in virtually any position to any thematic role of a predicate (e.g., Heim & Kratzer 1998; Pyllkkänen 2008; Bruening 2013, a.o.). Once again, we point out the issues that this alternative conceptualization has with restrictiveness (Collins 2024:156) and with complications to the computational system of the grammar.

Given these considerations, we can consistently define the positions for thematic arguments as follows: a THEME is the first argument externally Merged in the VP, an AGENT is the external argument externally Merged in the vP, above VP (Larson 1988), and a GOAL is an argument externally Merged in an intermediate position between the THEME and the AGENT. These considerations and conclusions echo those from Collins (2024).

In line with the theoretical assumptions outlined above, it must be the case that an external argument agent in passive contexts is externally Merged into a derivation above the internal argument theme, as follows.

- (42) The base positions of arguments in a transitive clause



Therefore, even in short passives, the external argument agent (which we have shown to be syntactically projected) is externally Merged in a position in which it asymmetrically c-commands the internal argument theme. These are the positions in which the arguments are externally Merged, and we have to make no exceptional stipulations about the nature of argument structure in the passive.

As for where the arguments end up in the passive derivation, it is clear that the internal argument theme goes to the position of the structural subject in Spanish. We know this because it very clearly surfaces in the nominative Case form and controls subject-verb agreement (43a), can undergo subject raising (43b), and canonically appears in a preverbal position (43a, b).

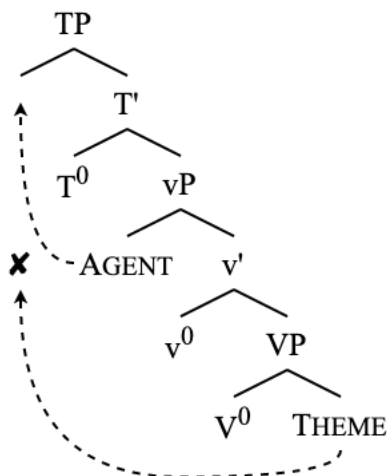
- (43) a. (Tú) fuiste detenido por la policía.
 (you) were.2SG detained.SG.M by the police
 ‘You were detained by the police.’
 b. Este versículo parece ser leído en todas las bodas.
 this verse seems.3SG be.INF read.SG.M in all the weddings
 ‘This verse seems to be read in every wedding.’

Indeed, the internal argument being a subject is the very definition of a passive (Givón 1994; Legate 2021). Regarding the question of *how* the internal argument ends up in the structural subject position, this is less straightforward, since the external argument in (42) is a potential intervener for movement to the subject position. We discuss this issue now.

4.2 Minimality and smuggling

According to the structure in (42), the external argument agent in Spanish short passives is externally Merged in a position above the internal argument theme. While this makes perfect sense in terms of argument structure, there is now an issue of locality when it comes to the movement of the internal argument into the position of the structural subject: namely, that the external argument is a closer candidate. It is not immediately clear how to solve this problem without violating restrictions such as minimality (Rizzi 1990, a.o.).

- (44) Minimality issue for movement to subject of the internal argument



Assuming that the internal and external arguments are not featurally distinguishable from one another in a way that matters for subject movement in this instance (which would be an additional complication), we appear to be in a bind in terms of the internal argument moving to the subject position. Collins (2005, 2024) notes the same issue, and presents a solution in terms of smuggling. Here, we adopt this solution for Spanish passives as well. Smuggling is defined as follows.

- (45) *Smuggling* (Collins 2005:97)

Suppose a constituent YP contains XP. Furthermore, suppose that XP is inaccessible to Z because of the presence of W (a barrier, phase boundary, or an intervener for the Minimal Link Condition and/or Relativized Minimality), which blocks a syntactic relation between Z and XP (e.g., movement, Case checking, agreement, binding). If YP moves to a position c-commanding W, we say that YP smuggles XP past W.

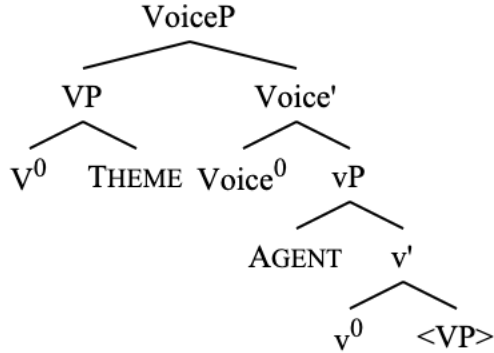
Imagining for a moment that movement is driven by feature valuation, it would look as follows:

- (46) a. $[Z_{[uF]} \dots [W_{[F]} \dots [Y_P X_{P[F]}]]]$
 └───────────┬───────────┘
 X
 b. $[Z_{[uF]} \dots [[Y_P X_{P[F]}]_i \dots [W_{[F]} \dots [<Y_P>]]]$
 └───────────┬───────────┘
 ✓

For passive smuggling derivations, we follow many others (Collins 2005, 2024; Blümel & Collins 2025; Storment 2025, 2026a; Russo Cardona 2026) in assuming that smuggling is driven in the passive by a functional projection VoiceP, which is responsible for moving a verbal functional projection containing the internal argument to a position where it is no longer blocked by the external argument (this is notably a different conception of VoiceP than as the projection that introduces the external argument, as in Kratzer 1996). Blümel & Collins (2025) motivate this movement in terms of labeling (Chomsky 2013; 2015), while Storment (2025, 2026a) motivates it in terms of an unvalued [V] feature on the voice head. Ultimately, we find that the labeling approach of Blümel & Collins works out with fewer technical assumptions than Storment's feature-valuation approach, though we do not discuss the details of this motivation here. What is crucial here is that the head that encodes the passive voice of the clause—Voice⁰—facilitates the

smuggling movement to a position where the internal argument is no longer blocked by the external argument, which allows the internal argument to move into the subject position. In a very basic sense, this would look as follows:

(47) Basic schema for smuggling⁶



This, of course, cannot be the whole story. Periphrastic passives additionally involve dedicated verbal morphology that must be explained. Collins (2005, 2024) connects the special participial morphology in the English passives to the presence of a participial head PartP externally Merged above VP. The presence of this PartP has historically been motivated in terms of Case absorption: the PartP absorbs accusative Case and prevents it from being assigned to the internal argument, since otherwise it would not be able to surface as a nominative subject. This kind of explanation is well-founded, going back to the Principles and Parameters tradition (Chomsky 1981; Chomsky & Lasnik 1993; Baker 2015, a.o.).

Though Collins (2005, 2024) does not adopt the Case-absorption view of PartP, we find this story to be especially empirically motivated for Spanish: in Spanish, unlike in English, nominative Case is clearly the unmarked Case form, with some authors claiming that nominative Case is actually the lack of Case in Spanish (e.g., Etxepare & Gallego 2020). In canonical non-passive transitive contexts (e.g., when there is an external argument), internal argument themes clearly receive accusative Case, which can be seen with factors such as the conditional availability of object clitic doubling. In passive contexts, there is clearly no accusative Case assigned to the internal argument. Given that we assume a transitive vP and typical argument structure in passive contexts, it is then necessary for some mechanism to prevent accusative Case from being assigned to the internal argument, so that it can move into position of the subject as a (potentially Caseless) nominative.

It is additionally necessary to have some such mechanism for absorbing internal argument Case for Spanish passives, especially since Spanish does seem to allow structural subjects to bear internal argument Case in certain contexts, such as with certain dative experiencer subjects (Fernández-Soriano 1999; Cuervo 2003, 2020; Fábregas et al. 2017; Herbeck 2022, a.o.). In other

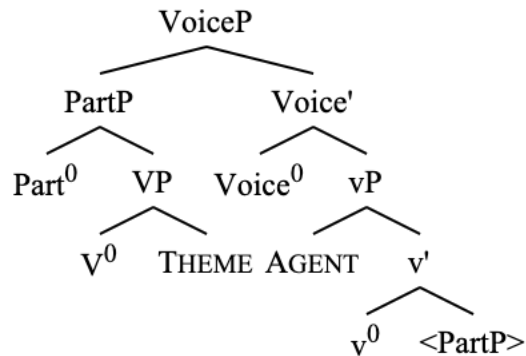
⁶ There is a question of how to ensure that an algorithm such as Minimal Search (MS) would determine that the internal argument theme is the “closer” candidate for subject movement than the external argument agent in this structure here, since it is not the case that the theme asymmetrically c-commands the agent. Storment (2026a) addresses this issue in detail, showing that it is actually not necessary for the arguments in smuggling configurations to asymmetrically c-command one another, and that a search algorithm will reliably find the internal argument before the external argument in a configuration such as (47) so long as the constituent that moves to Spec, VoiceP is non-phasal.

words, without the PartP, there is in principle nothing independently available to rule out a subject marked with internal argument Case in short passives in Spanish, which is crucially impossible.

- (48) **A mí me fui detenido por la policía.
 to me me.CL was.1SG detained.SG.M by the police
 int: ‘I was detained by the police.’

Thus, we should have a structure as follows.

- (49) Passive PartP as the smuggled constituent

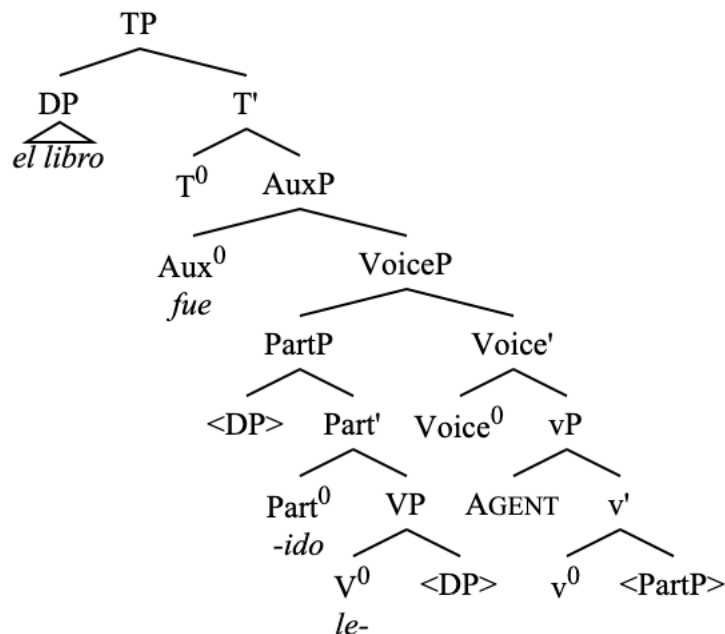


Collins additionally argues that the internal argument moves through the specifier of PartP in order to move out of the smuggling configuration, which is another point that we find well-motivated for Spanish since agreement between the internal argument subject and the participial verb is obligatory in passive contexts. Given that it is possible for agreement to obtain in Spec-Head configurations with minimal technological assumptions (Chomsky 2015), the fact that participial verbs in passives must agree with the subject (which, notably, is not the case for other participles in Spanish) can be naturally accounted for in the Collins (2005, 2024) smuggling account of the passive, since the internal argument moves through Spec,PartP.

As such, we can present the following complete derivation of the passive as a smuggling configuration (51) for the following example (50).

- (50) El libro fue leído.
 the book was.3SG read.SG.M
 ‘The book was read.’

(51) Smuggling derivation of the Spanish short passive



This structure exactly mirrors the analysis of the English short passive from Collins, and, as we have mentioned, neatly accounts for several properties of the Spanish construction as well: namely, that the subject is canonically preverbal, that the internal argument does not surface with accusative Case, and that the participial verb obligatorily agrees in features with the internal argument subject.

To return to the question of where the external argument ends up, it is clear from this structure that it remains in-situ: it does not move anywhere. In fact, given the fact that the internal argument is what becomes the structural subject, there is no reason to assume that it should move anywhere. The assumption that the external argument does not move is consistent with the empirical behavior of the external argument discussed in Sects. 2 and 3.

From its base position, the external argument can license agent-oriented SDPs, which we take to be adjoined to vP (Williams 1980; Roberts 1988; Mallén 1991; Pylkkänen 2008; Collins 2024; Storment 2026b) and controlled by the external argument that they are coreferent with. Similarly, the PRO subjects of purpose clauses can be controlled from this position, analyzing the purpose clauses as adjuncts that are attached in a similar position.

Furthermore, the external argument can bind anaphoric adjuncts such as ‘by X’s self’ from this position, as well as reflexive anaphor recipients, which, according to the discussion around (42), are necessarily externally merged in a position where they are c-commanded by the external arguments (if we assume that the thematic notion of RECIPIENT is more or less equivalent with that of a GOAL).

We additionally see that the fact that the covert external argument alternates with an optional overt realization of the external argument—a *by*-phrase, as in (1)—to be a kind of rather indirect evidence that there is a syntactically-projected external argument in the short passive, and especially that the external argument remains in-situ, since *by*-phrases notably must follow the verbal auxiliary and participial (without some additional movement such as topicalization), which is where the external argument would surface in (51) if it were pronounced overtly.

- (52) El libro (*por el lingüista) fue (*por el lingüista) leído (por el lingüista).
 the book (*by the linguist) was.3SG(*by the linguist) read.SG.M (by the linguist)
 ‘The book was read by the linguist.’

This point regarding the *by*-phrase constitutes indirect evidence to the extent that this is the analysis that Collins (2005, 2024) gives to English passive *by*-phrases, and we have showed thus far that Spanish passives are compatible with Collins’ proposals, both in terms of the projection of the external argument and the smuggling derivation. Therefore, since Spanish passives also can appear with *by*-phrases, the natural assumption would be that *by*-phrases in Spanish are subject to the same analysis of those from English. Given that this paper has been entirely about short passives up to this point, which are characterized by the lack of a *by*-phrase, we abstain from further discussion of the syntax of *by*-phrases here.

4.3 MacDonald (2017) and inalienable possession

Returning explicitly to the status of the external argument, one piece of evidence discussed by MacDonald (2017) against the syntactic projection of the external argument is the impossibility of an inalienable possession interpretation of body part arguments with periphrastic passives.

As MacDonald shows, the body part DP internal arguments are interpreted as inalienably possessed by the understood agent with passive/impersonal *se* clauses. See the following.

- (53) a. Se levanta la mano para hacer una pregunta en clase. (MacDonald 2017:364)
 SE raise.3SG the hand for make.INF a question in class
 ‘One raises their hand to ask a question in class.’
 b. El profesor hizo una pregunta. Se levantaron las manos.
 the professor made.3SG a question. SE raised.3PL the hands
 ‘The professor asked a question. Their hands raised.’

Here in (53), the internal argument themes *la(s) mano(s)* ‘the hand(s)’ are naturally interpreted in both cases as being inalienably possessed by the external argument agent: i.e., the raiser. Notably, this is not possible with periphrastic passives.

- (54) La cabeza fue levantada (por Juan). (MacDonald 2017:365)
 the head was.3SG raised.SG.F (by Juan)
 ‘The head was raised (by Juan).’

In (54), an inalienable-possession interpretation is not available for the internal argument theme, even when there is an external argument agent expressed with a *by*-phrase. That is, the agent of the verb *levantar* ‘to raise’ cannot be interpreted as raising up his own head; rather, it must be the case that he is acting on some other head (someone else’s head, a disembodied head, a fake prop head, etc.).

MacDonald adopts a classic possessor-raising analysis of the sentences in (53), in which the external argument agent originates in a position internal to the internal argument theme (Kempchinsky 1992; Landau 1999; Nakamoto 2010; Deal 2013, a.o.). According to MacDonald (2017:360), “this approach accounts directly for some well-known properties of this inalienably-possessed body part construction, the first of which is that the closest c-commanding DP is interpreted as the inalienable possessor of the body part (Guéron 1983).” We find as well that a

possessor-raising analysis works quite well to explain these cases of inalienable possession, and see no need to stray from it. MacDonald thus connects the interpretive qualities of the examples in (53) to the fact the same inalienable possession relation holds in active transitive clauses:

- (55) a. Julia levantó la mano.
 Julia raised.3SG the hand
 ‘Julia raised her hand.’
 b. (Yo) tengo la cabeza enorme.
 (I) have.1SG the head enormous
 ‘I have an enormous head.’

And even with certain dative-experiencer predicates:

- (56) Me duele la cabeza.
 me.CL hurts.3SG the head
 ‘My head hurts.’

Under the possessor-raising account of these examples, we can represent the example in (56) with something like the following additional structure.

- (57) Me_i duele [la $\langle me_i \rangle$ cabeza].
 me.CL_i hurts.3SG [the $\langle me.CL_i \rangle$ head]
 ‘My head hurts.’

Following this reasoning, something like (53b) could be represented (more or less) as follows, with the *se* clitic itself being associated with the implicit external argument (Cinque 1988, a.o.), and, in this case, the inalienable possessor.

- (58) Se_i levantaron [las $\langle se_i \rangle$ manos].
 SE_i raised.3PL [the $\langle SE_i \rangle$ hands]
 ‘The hands raised.’

Thus, in both cases, we see the movement of the possessor from inside of the structure of the internal argument possessee to an argument position in which it c-commands the possessee itself.

MacDonald takes the lack of the inalienable-possession reading in the periphrastic passive example (54) to suggest that there actually is no external argument projected in the periphrastic passive (or, perhaps more accurately, that there is no external argument position available for a possessor to move into).

Throughout this paper, we have presented evidence supporting a view that external argument is syntactically projected in the short (periphrastic) passive. MacDonald is certainly correct in noting that an inalienable possession reading is not possible with periphrastic passives, though we find it necessary to propose an alternative account of the data that is compatible with the conclusions that we have drawn thus far.

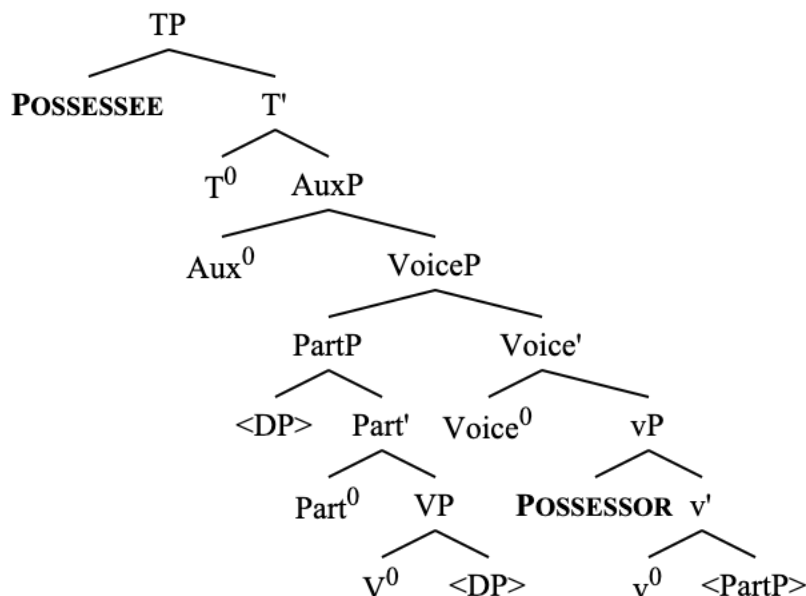
Fortunately, the smuggling derivation of the short passive presents us with a structure that is incompatible with a licit realization of inalienable possession. The conditions outlined for inalienable possession by MacDonald—and elsewhere (e.g., Guéron 1983, 1985; Rodrigues 2023)—cannot be met in the smuggling structure of the Spanish short passive: specifically, that

“the inalienable-possession interpretation [of the internal argument] requires the syntactic presence of a c-commanding possessor” (MacDonald 2017:380).

Returning to the smuggling structure in (51), we see clearly that the internal argument of the short passive undergoes movement to a position in which it is no longer c-commanded by the external argument. Additionally, given the facts shown by (43), we know that the internal argument undergoes movement to this position via A-movement, which is canonically known to alter the binding relations established by c-command of arguments from their respective A-positions.

Thus, we can explain the unavailability of an inalienable-possession reading in the short passive as a natural consequence of the structure of the smuggling derivation. If we do imagine a smuggling derivation of the periphrastic passive in which the external argument is the possessor and the internal argument subject is the possessee, we see that there is no c-command of the possessee by the intended possessor.

- (59) Smuggling and c-command between a possessor and possessee



The lack of c-command by the (potential) external argument possessor of the internal argument subject possessee is sufficient to explain why an inalienable-possession reading is unavailable in Spanish periphrastic passives, consistent with MacDonald’s discussion. Further, this lack of c-command—i.e., binding—of the possessee by the intended possessor can further explain why an external-argument-possessor reading is unavailable in passive derivations in which the internal argument subject involves overt possessive morphology (we follow Collins in assuming that the *by*-phrase is in the canonical external argument position).

- (60) *Su_i cabeza fue levantada por Juan_{*i/j}.*
 his_ihead was.3SG raised.SG.F by Juan_{*i/j}
 ‘His_i head was raised by Juan_{*i/j}.’

The same observation holds for for short passives (61).

- (61) Su pierna fue rota.
 his leg was.3SG broken.SG.F
 ‘His leg was broken.’

In (61), while such an interpretation could perhaps be pragmatically coerced, the natural interpretation is certainly that the possessor of the internal argument subject and the implicit argument agent of the main verb are not coreferent.

In other words, the lack of inalienable-possession readings of the periphrastic passive can be connected to more general principles of binding and possession under the smuggling analysis of the periphrastic passive, which does not require stipulating that there is no external argument present in the derivation, since the internal argument A-moves to a position where it is not c-commanded by external argument. These principles also explain why there is no inalienable-possession relation that can hold between non-passive derivations in which an intended possessor does not c-command an intended possessee, as follows.

- (62) La mano golpeó a Juan.
 the hand hit.3SG to Juan
 ‘The hand hit Juan.’

Here, it is not the case that there can be an inalienable possession interpretation between the external argument *la mano* ‘the hand’ and the internal argument *Juan*, again because *Juan* does not c-command the external argument. Thus, it is not necessary to make any conditional stipulations about the nature of argument structure, binding, or possession in order to explain why inalienable-possession readings are not available in the periphrastic passive in Spanish. These facts follow from general principles of binding, just as the data explored earlier in the paper follow from general principles of argument structure.

As such, we have seen several key pieces of evidence that there is an external argument syntactically projected in Spanish short passive clauses. These empirical findings, along with the Minimalist-theoretic considerations outlined throughout the paper, motivate an analysis of the Spanish short passive as a smuggling derivation. Given the similarities between the Spanish and English short passives, we straightforwardly adopt the smuggling analysis of short passives from Collins (2005, 2024). We find that several morphosyntactic properties of the short passive are naturally explained under this analysis. We summarize these findings here.

- (63) *Properties of the Spanish short passive*
- a. Syntactically projected external argument
 - i. Licenses agent-oriented SDPs.
 - ii. Controls big PRO subject of embedded purpose clauses.
 - iii. Reflexive anaphors obey Condition A of the Binding Theory.
 - iv. Non-reflexive pronouns obey Condition B of the Binding Theory.
 - b. Reflexive pronominals with *mismo* in the short passive do not behave as logophors
 - i. Necessarily carry a bound anaphor interpretation.
 - ii. No semantically vacuous alternation with non-reflexive pronouns.
 - iii. Reflexive strong pronoun *sí*, which cannot be a logophor, is licit in short passives.
 - c. Short passive as a smuggling derivation
 - i. Arguments externally Merged AGENT > THEME.

- ii. Internal argument is smuggled within verbal projection via VoiceP.
- iii. PartP absorbs internal argument Case, preventing non-nominative subject.
- iv. Internal argument moving through Spec,PartP accounts for participial agreement.
- v. Smuggling structure incompatible with possessor raising.

5 Conclusion

In this paper, we have systematically presented evidence for the syntactic projection of the external argument in Spanish short passive derivations. Based on the empirical facts presented here, as well as the theoretical context of our discussion of the data, we conclude definitively that there is an external argument projected in the syntax of the short passive in Spanish (contra MacDonald 2017). These observations connect to a broader literature that argues for the projection of the external argument in passive contexts (Baker et al. 1989; Collins 2005, 2024; Roberts 2019; Angelopoulos et al. 2020; Gotah 2024; Sulemana 2024; Ndapo 2025; Russo Cardona 2026, a.o.).

One crucial piece of evidence for the syntactic projection of the implicit argument has been the behavior of reflexive pronominal expressions that can appear in short passive contexts. Such examples have been discussed for English (Collins 2005, 2024), and we have demonstrated that Spanish behaves the same way. In addition to the fact that these reflexive pronominals are not interpreted as exempt logophors, we have shown additional morphological evidence that these elements in short passives cannot be reasonably analyzed as exempt logophors, based on the distribution of *si*. In this way, we have connected Spanish to the discussion of unambiguously non-logophoric reflexive pronominal elements being licensed in short passive contexts as they are in other languages such as Greek (Angelopoulos et al. 2020) and Italian (Russo Cardona 2026).

Further, we have shown that Collins' analysis of smuggling in the short passive is well-motivated in Spanish, and naturally explains several core properties of the construction, such as the nature of the participial verbal morphology (including the fact that it must agree with the internal argument subject), and the fact that the subject must appear with nominative Case and in a canonically-preverbal position.

In addition to Collins' analysis of the English passive as a smuggling derivation, this analysis has been advocated for a number of the world's languages, including Italian (Russo Cardona 2026), Oshiwambo (Ndapo 2025), Ewe (Gotah 2024), and Bùlì (Sulemana 2024). Smuggling approaches to the passive have been additionally adopted by Roberts (2019, 2024), as well as by Hyams & Snyder (2005) and Snyder & Hyams (2015), and smuggling has been shown to be useful in explaining other argument alternations such as inversion (Shlonsky 2024; Storment 2025, 2026a) and dative shift (Collins 2021; Newman 2024; Thoms 2024).

Looking to the future, we bring up the possibility that the core tenets of this proposal can be applied to other passive/impersonal voice alternations in Spanish, such as those marked by *se*. The Spanish passive *se* construction has been argued to involve a syntactically-projected external argument (e.g., MacDonald 2017), an idea that is well-founded in Romance impersonal *se/si* constructions going back to Cinque (1988), and the possibility of smuggling in Italian impersonal *si* clauses has been discussed by Russo Cardona (2026).

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